



A videogame called House of the Dead: Overkill has become the most profane ever — it drops the F-bomb 189 times, or about once per minute

PIMP THIS BUM!

Siddharth Parwatay

Until recently Tim Edwards was just another one of those sign-board holding bums at a busy Houston underpass; ignored by most people. But now he has taken his bumming to a whole new level — Cyber Space. That's right; meet the world's first online bum!

How did this most unlikely enterprise begin and what does being an online bum mean, anyway? It began with a twist of fate and a father-son duo trying to come up with a marketing campaign that ended up in the form of www.pimpthisbum.com. A website with an intentionally controversial name where Edwards gives regular webcasts to curious visitors who ask questions about Edwards' life and his decline of fortune from being a regular job holder with a home, to a hopeless roadside bum. It's also a front where visitors can donate money, goods and perhaps moral support to help Edwards get back on track. Sounds ridiculous right? But that's exactly what Kevin Dolan and his son Sean wanted to do — insult people's sensitivities so that they would go to the site and see Tim. Had the site been called HelpTim.com or something similar, people would have ignored the site, goes their theory. The Dolans initially wanted to just promote their budding internet marketing business until Sean hit upon this idea and decided to do some good, while they're at it.

Tim on the other hand is quite the charmer, and people seem to instantly fall in love with him. He's got an easy going attitude and doesn't blame the world for his plight. The web site features YouTube videos of Tim going about his daily Bumming duties and visitors can even follow his activities through a live day and night Web cast.

Visitors also get regular updates on his path to recovery. These include checking into an alcohol rehab program and plans to shave his beard and trim his hair. His detox program begins soon at the Seattle-based Sunray Treatment and Recovery, which is providing the \$13,800, for the 35-day program, free of charge. There are plans to air

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web casts as Edwards goes through the program. People have even donated their flier miles to cover his travel. What's funny is that he's actually got a nice thing going for himself, so why would he ever want to stop being a bum?

Some activists are claiming that this does little to address the hard truth of



Pimp these Facts

Edwards had been homeless since Aug. 19, 2004 (he remembers the exact date)

Some rules he lives by: Keep to your own territory. Beg enough for the bare necessities — food, cigarettes, drink — then get off the corner. Learn whom to trust and whom to stay away from.

His descent into homelessness began after the deaths of his mother and grandmother. He says many of his fellow homeless friends have just died because they lost hope.

Edwards says he has tried programs aimed at getting the homeless off the streets, but none have worked for him. Tim used to own a car and house and was an office manager. Tim collects Pesos. He gets a lot of them. Speaking of other addictions he says he was addicted to the game EverQuest

being homeless. Tim doesn't care though. "There's always someone who's gonna take offence to anything" says the disenchanted Hobo adding "If you help an old lady across the street there's someone who's gonna take offence to that too!" He is quite hopeful that this online exercise will also help alleviate the condition of his fellow comrades on the streets. Anthony Love, president of the Coalition for the Homeless of Houston/Harris County has an interesting take on the matter. He says, "He is a person. His name is Tim. And to pimp anyone is not something I would endorse".